v1.1 · April 2026

Pier

# How Pier *takes care* of your website.

A friendly walkthrough for anyone who runs a website but doesn't write code. Fix the homepage, clean up old pages, update prices, find broken links — by asking in plain language.

WELCOME

# Your website, without the hassle.

If you've ever paid a developer €80 to fix a typo, or spent an evening hunting through folders you don't understand trying to change the phone number in the footer — this guide is for you.

Pier is a small app for your Mac. You open it, connect to your website the way a developer would, and then you *talk* to it. You don't need to know what a file is, or where the homepage "lives". You type things like:

YOU SAY

*"Can you change the phone number on every page to 020-123-4567?"*

PIER DOES

Searches your site, finds every page that mentions the old number, shows you the exact lines it wants to change, waits for you to say yes, then makes a safe backup and applies the change. If anything looks wrong afterwards, one click puts it back.

That's the whole idea. You describe what you want. Pier does the careful, fiddly, technical work in the background. Nothing changes on your website until you say so.

This guide walks you through everything you can do with Pier, organised by the sort of job you might want to get done. No jargon. No code. Just the things you can ask for, and what you'll see when you do.

Pier is made by a small Dutch company — A Brand New Company — with offices in Amsterdam and an outpost in Thailand. We build tools for people who own websites, not just the developers who built them.

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"Maintaining a website shouldn't feel like defusing a bomb. It should feel like *having a quiet word* with someone who knows your site inside out."

— THE IDEA BEHIND PIER

CHAPTER 01

# What Pier is for.

Pier is the app you open when you want to change something on your website, but you don't want to (or can't) open a code editor. It was built for three kinds of people.

### The site owner who inherited the site

You didn't build the site. Maybe a freelancer did, years ago. They left a pile of folders you don't really understand, and every time something needs updating, you either pay someone or just let it slide. Pier reads the site, tells you what's there in plain words, and makes the changes for you.

### The small-agency generalist

You manage websites for clients. Some are WordPress, some are Joomla, one is a hand-coded thing from 2014 nobody wants to touch. You used to switch between four different tools. Now you open one app, connect to whatever the client gave you, and ask.

### The developer who's tired of being the copy editor

You build sites for a living. You don't want to be the person who changes opening hours or swaps out a photo for the twentieth time. You hand Pier to your client. They do the small stuff themselves. Pier's safety net means nothing they do can seriously break anything.

WHAT PIER IS NOT

Pier isn't a website *builder*. It doesn't replace WordPress, Squarespace, or your designer. It's a careful assistant for a site that already exists. If you want to launch a brand new website from scratch, Pier isn't the right tool.

Pier also isn't a monitoring tool, a hosting provider, or a backup service for everything you own online. It connects to one site at a time, helps you work on it, keeps copies of what it changes, and hands back control when you're done.

CHAPTER 02

# Installing Pier on your Mac.

Pier is a native Mac app. You download one file, drag it into your Applications folder, and open it. That's it.

## What you need

- A Mac running **macOS 13 (Ventura) or newer**. Both Apple Silicon (M1/M2/M3) and older Intel Macs work — one download, both architectures.
- About **100 MB** of free disk space.
- The details your hosting provider gave you when they set up your site (host, username, password). If you don't have these, skip to Chapter 04 first — we'll tell you what to ask them for.

## Step by step

01 **Download the installer.**
Visit pier.abn.company/download and click the big "Download for Mac" button. The file is about 65 MB and arrives as a *.dmg* — the standard Mac installer format.

02 **Open the installer.**
Double-click the downloaded file. A little window appears with the Pier logo and an Applications folder.

03 **Drag Pier into Applications.**
Drag the Pier icon across onto the Applications folder. Wait a second while it copies over.

04 **Eject the installer.**
In Finder's sidebar, click the small "eject" arrow next to the Pier installer. You can now delete the original downloaded file — the app is safely in Applications.

05 **Open Pier.**
Find Pier in Launchpad or your Applications folder and double-click. The first time you open a new Mac app, macOS takes a moment to verify it — this is normal and only happens once.

# What you'll see when Pier opens.

> IF MACOS BLOCKS PIER ON FIRST OPEN
>
> Occasionally macOS will say "Pier cannot be opened because Apple cannot check it for malicious software." This is Apple being extra careful on brand-new software. Right-click the Pier icon in Applications, choose **Open**, then click **Open** in the dialog. After that, Pier opens normally forever.

The first time you open Pier, you see the welcome screen: a large Pier logo, a short message, and a box asking for your license key. We'll deal with licenses in the next chapter.

After you've entered your license once, Pier remembers it forever on that Mac. Opening Pier again takes you straight to your list of connections — the websites you've already added — or an empty list if this is your first time.

## The layout, at a glance

- **Left sidebar** — the list of websites you've connected. Click one to open it.
- **Middle** — when you're inside a site, this shows the chat. Type what you want, hit Enter, Pier does it.
- **Right sidebar** — when relevant, shows the file or change Pier is currently working on. Diffs, previews, that sort of thing.
- **Top bar** — connection name, a connect/disconnect toggle, and a settings cog.

That's the whole interface. There's no steep learning curve. If you can use a messaging app, you can use Pier.

## Keeping Pier up to date

Pier checks for updates when you open it. If a new version is available, you'll see a gentle note in the settings menu. You can install the update immediately, later today, or never — it's your call. Your data and connections are preserved across updates.

CHAPTER 03

# Unlocking Pier with your license.

Pier is a one-time purchase — €199, once, no subscription. Your license covers **two Macs**, so you can use it on a desktop and a laptop, or at work and at home.

## How to buy

If you haven't already, go to pier.abn.company and click Buy Pier. You pay through Stripe — card, iDEAL, Bancontact and more are accepted. After payment you receive an email (usually within a minute) with:

- Your license key — a long code starting with **pier_**.
- A PDF receipt for your records.
- A link to download Pier, in case you haven't yet.

## How to activate

01 **Copy the license key from your email.**
Don't worry if it breaks across two lines in the email — Pier handles that.

02 **Paste it into Pier.**
On the welcome screen, paste the key into the box and click *Activate*.

03 **Done.**
Pier checks your key, claims one of your two seats, and unlocks the full app. You never have to enter the key again on this Mac.

> THE 2-SEAT RULE, IN PLAIN ENGLISH
>
> You can use Pier on two different Macs at once. If you ever want to move your license to a third Mac (new laptop, replacement after a spill), go to Settings → License on the old Mac and click *Deactivate*. That frees the seat immediately. If you no longer have access to the old Mac, email us — we'll free it manually within one working day.

# Offline & if you change your mind.

## Your license while you're offline

Pier checks in with our server about once a week to confirm your license is still good. If you're on a plane, on holiday, or our server is briefly down, Pier doesn't care — it keeps working for a whole week without checking in. After that, you'll see a small "please reconnect" note in settings. No lockouts, no surprises.

## If you change your mind

We offer a **14-day, no-questions-asked refund**. If Pier isn't what you hoped for within two weeks of purchase, reply to your purchase email or write to info@abn.company. We'll send your money back within a few days, and your license is automatically deactivated.

## What a license covers

| What | You get |
|---|---|
| Price | €199 one-time, VAT included for EU individuals |
| Seats | Two Macs at a time, freely swappable |
| Sites you can manage | Unlimited — add as many websites as you like |
| Updates | All future improvements to Pier 1 are free. Pier 2, if it ever exists, will be a separate purchase |
| Support | Email info@abn.company; we answer within one working day |
| Refund window | 14 days from purchase, no reason needed |

There's no subscription. We don't store your credit card. If you never open Pier again after buying, we never send you another bill.

CHAPTER 04

# Connecting to your website.

Before Pier can help you, it needs to know where your website lives and how to sign in. This is a one-time setup per site — five minutes, once, then it's saved.

## What you need from your hosting company

Every hosting provider gives you these details when they set up your account. If you don't have them, find the welcome email from your host, or log into the hosting dashboard and look under *FTP accounts* or *File access*. You're looking for four things:

| Thing | Also called |
|---|---|
| Host | "FTP server", "hostname", "host address". Looks like *ftp.example.com* or a row of numbers. |
| Username | "FTP user", "login name". Often the same as your hosting account name. |
| Password | "FTP password". Not usually the same as your hosting dashboard password. |
| Type of connection | "FTP", "FTPS", or "SFTP". Ask your host which they support. Pier speaks all three. |

## Which type of connection should you pick?

All three get Pier onto your site. The differences are about *how securely* the password travels across the internet.

- **SFTP** — the modern, secure default. Pick this if your host offers it. Nothing travels unencrypted.
- **FTPS** — also secure, just an older design. Perfectly fine.
- **FTP** — unencrypted. Only use this if the other two aren't available on your host, and only over a private network. Almost all modern hosts support at least FTPS.

If you're not sure, pick **SFTP** first and try it. Pier tells you immediately whether the connection works.

# Adding the connection in Pier.

01 **Click "Add a connection".**
On the home screen of Pier, click the plus button in the top-left. A form appears.

02 **Give it a friendly name.**
"Client X — production" is more useful six months from now than "ftp01.greenhosting.com". This is only for you.

03 **Enter host, username, and password.**
Straight from your hosting welcome email.

04 **Pick the connection type.**
SFTP, FTPS, or FTP, as discussed on the previous page. Pier fills in the right port number automatically.

05 **Click Test.**
Pier tries to sign in. If everything is right, you see a green tick and "Connected — your site has X files in the root folder". If something is wrong, you see a friendly message explaining what.

06 **Save.**
Once the test succeeds, hit Save. Your connection lives in the sidebar now, and you can click it to start work.

TWO SETTINGS WORTH UNDERSTANDING

**Working folder** — if your hosting account holds more than one website (a "multi-domain" setup), point Pier at the folder of the specific site you want to work on. This stops Pier from wandering into the wrong site by accident.

**Read-only mode** — a safety switch. When it's on, Pier can look at your site but cannot change anything. Some people turn this on for the live production site and off for staging. You can flip it at any time.

# What Pier recognises automatically.

The moment Pier connects, it quietly scans your site and figures out what's there. Is it a WordPress site? Drupal? Joomla? How many domains are on this account? Where's the homepage? This takes about ten seconds and then Pier knows its way around — so the very first thing you ask doesn't require you to explain where anything is.

On connect, Pier looks for the telltale signs of these systems and sets itself up accordingly. You don't have to tell it; it just knows.

| System | What Pier will know |
|---|---|
| WordPress | Active theme, plugins, admin URL, database credentials from *wp-config* |
| Joomla | Installed template, components, database from *configuration.php* |
| Drupal | Installed modules, themes, site structure |
| Magento & PrestaShop | Shop templates, themes, environment configuration |
| Laravel & other PHP apps | Project layout, environment files, entry point |
| Plain HTML sites | All of your pages, images, and stylesheets, ready to browse |

If you have several sites on one hosting account, Pier shows a small picker in the chat: "I see three sites here — which one shall we work on?" You click the site you want, and Pier focuses on that one.

> YOU DON'T NEED TO KNOW WHICH ONE YOU HAVE
>
> Don't know whether your site is WordPress or Joomla? It doesn't matter. Connect with your FTP details and Pier tells you. You can also just ask: *"What kind of website is this?"*

CHAPTER 05

# Your first conversation with Pier.

Click a connection and you're in the chat. This is where you'll spend most of your time with Pier. Here's how to talk to it.

## Just say what you want

You don't need a special way of phrasing things. Write the way you'd write to a thoughtful colleague. Short sentences are fine. Long explanations are fine. If you're not sure how to describe the change, describe the result you want — Pier will figure out the how.

YOU SAY

*"The phone number on the homepage is wrong. It should say 020-123-4567. Can you fix it everywhere you find it?"*

PIER DOES

Scans your site for the old number, finds eight places (homepage, contact page, footer on every page, an email-signup form). Shows you each change side-by-side. Waits for your approval. When you say yes, it updates them all and tells you what changed.

## English or Dutch, as you prefer

Pier understands both. You can even mix them — write part of a sentence in Dutch, the rest in English, and Pier follows along. Replies come back in whichever language you used last.

## What the tiny grey lines in the chat mean

You'll sometimes see short, faded lines that look like *"reading homepage.html"* or *"searching for 'phone'…"*. These are Pier narrating what it's doing so you can see the work happen. You can ignore them — they're there for transparency, not for you to memorise.

# How a change actually happens.

This is the single most important thing to understand about Pier. No change ever lands on your website without your explicit OK.

01 **You ask.**
You type the thing you want changed.

02 **Pier looks.**
It reads the files it needs to read to understand the request. If you asked about "the homepage", it reads the homepage. If you asked about "every page", it reads them all.

03 **Pier proposes.**
Instead of changing anything, it shows you a little card: "Here's the file, here's what I want to change, here's why". Red lines are what would come out, green lines are what would go in. Exactly like the "track changes" view you know from Word.

04 **You decide.**
Accept, reject, or say "actually, do it differently". Saying no doesn't annoy Pier — it just drafts a new proposal.

05 **Pier applies.**
Once you click Accept, Pier makes a safe copy of the original (so you can always go back), uploads the new version, and shows you a green "Done" with a small *Undo* button that lives for 10 seconds.

> READ EVERY CHANGE BEFORE ACCEPTING
>
> Pier is good, but it's not infallible. The whole workflow is built around you being able to catch anything that looks off. The diff view (red/green) is your last check. If something makes you pause for a moment, reject it and ask Pier to try again.

## Undoing a change you already accepted

Click *Undo* in the green toast within 10 seconds and you're back to before. After the toast fades, go to *History* on the file (or just ask Pier: "put back the version from five minutes ago"). Pier keeps every change for a rolling 90 days or the last 20 versions of each file, whichever runs out first.

CHAPTER 06

# Things you can just ask.

A tour of the jobs Pier handles well. Use these as inspiration — your own needs will be different, but the pattern is the same: you describe the outcome, Pier figures out the how.

## Everyday edits

"CHANGE THE OFFICE HOURS ON THE CONTACT PAGE TO MONDAY-FRIDAY 9-17."
PIER FINDS THE CONTACT PAGE, PROPOSES THE EDIT, WAITS FOR YOUR OK.

"SWAP THE HERO PHOTO ON THE HOMEPAGE FOR THE ONE IN /IMAGES/UPLOADS/2026-TEAM.JPG."
PIER UPDATES THE HOMEPAGE SO IT POINTS TO THE NEW PHOTO, PROPOSES THE CHANGE.

"THE FOOTER STILL HAS 2024 IN THE COPYRIGHT. MAKE IT AUTO-UPDATE TO THE CURRENT YEAR."
EDITS THE FOOTER ONCE, PROPERLY, SO IT'S NEVER WRONG AGAIN.

## Site-wide clean-up

"EVERY LINK TO OUR OLD-DOMAIN.COM — PLEASE CHANGE IT TO NEW-DOMAIN.COM."
SEARCHES, FINDS 47 REFERENCES ACROSS 12 PAGES, SHOWS THEM IN A SINGLE REVIEW PANE, UPDATES THEM IN ONE GO.

"REMOVE THE MENTION OF PRODUCT Y — WE DON'T SELL IT ANY MORE."
LISTS EVERY PAGE THAT MENTIONS PRODUCT Y, PROPOSES PER-PAGE EDITS (OR DELETIONS WHERE THE WHOLE PAGE WAS ABOUT Y), YOU DECIDE PAGE BY PAGE.

# More things you can just ask.

## Things you can't even see from the outside

"ARE THERE ANY PAGES THAT DON'T HAVE A PAGE TITLE?"
CHECKS EVERY PAGE, SHOWS YOU THE ONES MISSING A TITLE, OFFERS TO DRAFT A SENSIBLE ONE FOR EACH.

"IS THERE STILL A COOKIE BANNER ON THE SITE? I THOUGHT WE REMOVED IT."
SCANS FOR COOKIE-RELATED CODE, TELLS YOU YES OR NO, SHOWS YOU WHERE.

"ADD A COOKIE BANNER TO THE BOTTOM OF EVERY PAGE — WITH AN ACCEPT BUTTON AND A DECLINE BUTTON."
DRAFTS A BANNER, SHOWS YOU THE EXACT HTML AND STYLES IT WANTS TO ADD, EXPLAINS WHERE ON EACH PAGE IT WILL GO. YOU ACCEPT ONCE AND IT'S LIVE EVERYWHERE.

## Questions Pier can answer

"WHICH PAGES HAVEN'T BEEN UPDATED IN OVER A YEAR?"
LOOKS AT THE MODIFICATION DATES, GIVES YOU A SORTED LIST.

"WHERE ON MY SITE DO I MENTION COMPANY Z?"
EXACT LIST OF PAGES, WITH THE SURROUNDING SENTENCE FOR CONTEXT.

"WHAT THEME OR DESIGN IS THIS SITE USING?"
LOOKS UP THE ACTIVE THEME, TELLS YOU THE NAME, WHO MADE IT, AND WHICH VERSION.

# And the bigger jobs.

## WordPress-flavoured tasks

```
"ADD A NEW PAGE CALLED 'ABOUT US', USING THE SAME LAYOUT AS THE
SERVICES PAGE."
READS THE SERVICES PAGE, DRAFTS THE NEW PAGE WITH THE SAME STRUCTURE
BUT EMPTY CONTENT BLOCKS, PROPOSES THE CREATE.
```

```
"WHY IS MY SITE LOADING SLOWLY?"
RUNS THE PERFORMANCE AUDIT: CHECKS IMAGE SIZES, FLAGS SLOW SCRIPTS,
RECOMMENDS CONCRETE FIXES, OFFERS TO APPLY THEM.
```

## Webshop tasks

```
"MARK THE RED T-SHIRT (SKU RTS-003) AS OUT OF STOCK."
LOOKS UP THE PRODUCT IN YOUR SHOP DATABASE, PROPOSES THE SINGLE ROW
UPDATE, WAITS FOR YOUR OK.
```

```
"CHANGE ALL VAT RATES FROM 21% TO THE NEW RATE OF 22%."
FINDS EVERY PLACE THE RATE IS STORED (SETTINGS, PRODUCTS, TAX
RULES), PROPOSES THE CHANGES IN ONE BATCH.
```

## Bits you can always fall back on

If you're stuck, you can also just ask Pier:

- "What can you do?"
- "How do I change X?"
- "I want to do Y — where should I start?"

It'll answer in plain language, usually with a suggested first step you can say yes to.

CHAPTER 07

# How Pier keeps you safe.

The thing that lets you relax when you're editing a real, live site is that Pier is obsessive about putting things back the way they were if you change your mind.

## Every change gets a backup before it happens

The moment you accept a change, Pier takes a snapshot of the original file and files it away on your Mac. The new version goes up on your website; the old version sits safely on your disk, labelled with the exact time it was replaced. You can return to any version at any time.

## The 10-second undo

Just after any change lands, a green "Done" toast appears with an *Undo* button. If something looks wrong when you see the result, click Undo and you're exactly where you were.

## The file history

Past 10 seconds? No problem. Every file has a history of every version Pier has ever made. Right-click the file in Pier's sidebar, or just ask: *"show me the history of the homepage"*.

## Full-site snapshots before big jobs

Before a large refactor — "rewrite every product description", "swap out the whole theme" — you can ask Pier: *"make a snapshot of the site called 'before the theme change'"*. Pier zips up everything, stores it on your Mac, and now you have a one-click "put everything back to how it was" button waiting for you.

> IN THE WORST CASE
>
> Even in the worst case — you accepted a change, you didn't undo within 10 seconds, the site went down, and it's three days later — as long as you still have Pier installed, you can restore the previous version. The clock only starts once the on-disk backups expire (90 days by default, configurable).

# The small extra safeties.

### "High-risk" warnings

Some files are disproportionately scary to break — the ones that control who can log in, how the site is wired up, how pages are routed. When Pier proposes a change to one of these, the card is marked in amber and the diff gets extra real-estate. It's Pier gently saying: *look twice here*.

### Read-only mode for the live site

If you want, flip the "read-only" switch on your production connection. Pier can still help you investigate, explain, and plan — it just refuses to change anything. When you're ready, flip it back off for a few minutes, make the change, flip it back on.

### Working folder — the invisible guard rail

If your hosting account has five websites on it, and you only want Pier to work on one of them, set the working folder to that site. From that point on, Pier literally cannot see or touch the other four — they're out of its view until you choose otherwise.

### Passwords never leave your Mac

Your website password goes from your hard drive directly to your web server, encrypted in transit. We never see it, the AI never sees it, no one else's computer ever sees it.

### Things Pier won't do, ever

- Make a change without proposing it first (with exactly two exceptions: creating a new folder, and renaming a file — both reversible in seconds).
- Delete everything on your site in one go. There is no "rm -rf" button, deliberately.
- Change your database in bulk. Every row update is one-at-a-time, with the row shown first.
- Share your site's content with anyone. Your files stay between you and your hosting.

CHAPTER 08

# The audits — free site health checks.

Pier includes a handful of pre-packaged investigations. Each one scans your site with a specific question in mind and comes back with a list of findings plus, where it's safe, proposed fixes.

| Audit | What it checks |
|---|---|
| SEO | Page titles, meta descriptions, share images, structured data. The kind of thing Google grades you on. |
| Security | Passwords or keys accidentally left in files, outdated patterns, mixed "http/https" assets that make browsers complain. |
| Performance | Oversized images, scripts that slow down page loading, missing cache settings. |
| Accessibility | Images missing descriptions for screen readers, unlabelled form fields, poor colour contrast. |
| Broken links | Any link on your site that goes nowhere. |
| Meta descriptions | Pages missing the short summary Google shows in search results. |
| Viewport | Pages that break on phones because they don't have the right mobile setting. |
| Analytics | Is your tracking correctly installed? Any obvious mistakes? |
| External links | Links to other websites that open in the same tab (usually you want them to open in a new one). |
| Full audit | Runs every audit above in one sitting. Takes a few minutes. |

To run one, just ask: *"run the SEO audit on the whole site"*, or *"check for broken links"*, or *"do a full audit"*. Pier returns the findings, and for many of them, offers to fix them for you directly. As always, every fix is a proposal you approve before it lands.

# What the audits *don't* do.

Pier's audits are honest. They find real problems and propose real fixes. But they don't:

- **Guarantee you'll rank #1 on Google.** SEO is 70% writing and 30% technical. Pier catches the technical half.
- **Replace a proper security audit for a high-value site.** If you run a bank, hire a security firm. If you run a small business, Pier will catch the stuff that most small businesses get wrong.
- **Load-test your site.** Pier inspects what's on the server; it doesn't simulate 10,000 visitors. Tools for that exist and complement Pier well.
- **Follow links off your own website.** The broken-link audit checks your own site's pages exist, not that the external sites you link to are still alive.

> OUR HONEST RECOMMENDATION
>
> Run a full audit once when you first connect, accept the fixes that make sense, and then run it every few months after big changes. You'll find that most of the improvements Pier suggests are small and easy to accept — they accumulate into a much healthier site over a year.

CHAPTER 09

# Working with your database.

Most websites keep their "content" (pages, posts, products, customers, orders) in a separate database. Pier can read and change this database too — carefully.

## How Pier connects to your database

When you first connect, Pier reads your site's configuration and discovers which databases are in use, their names, and how to connect to them. You don't tell Pier anything; it just figures it out.

Then, before it reads or writes anything, Pier asks permission. You click "install the database helper". Pier puts a small, password-protected helper file onto your server that lets it talk to the database directly. That helper self-destructs after 24 hours of silence, so nothing is ever left lying around.

## Read first, write only with permission

Straight out of the box, the helper only lets Pier *look* at the database. It can list every product, every customer, every order — but nothing can be changed. This is deliberate.

When you ask Pier to change something — "mark this product out of stock", "fix the typo in the t-shirt description" — it pauses and explicitly asks: "OK to enable write mode for this database?". Only after you say yes does it reinstall the helper in write mode and proceed with the change.

> ROW BY ROW, ALWAYS
>
> Even with write mode on, Pier only ever changes one row at a time. It can't delete a whole table. It can't drop all your products in one command. Every single change is a proposal you approve separately.

# Common database jobs.

```
"WHAT ARE THE TOP 10 BEST-SELLING PRODUCTS THIS YEAR?"
LOOKS AT YOUR ORDERS, RANKS THEM, SHOWS YOU A CLEAN TABLE.
```

```
"FIND THE CUSTOMER WITH EMAIL JAN@EXAMPLE.COM AND TELL ME WHEN THEY
LAST ORDERED."
READS THE CUSTOMER RECORD, REPORTS THE LAST ORDER DATE.
```

```
"UPDATE EVERY PRODUCT IN THE 'SUMMER' CATEGORY TO BE ON SALE, 20%
OFF."
LISTS THE PRODUCTS, PROPOSES EACH ROW CHANGE INDIVIDUALLY, LETS YOU
APPROVE THEM IN ONE BATCH OR ONE-BY-ONE.
```

```
"DELETE THE TEST ORDER FROM LAST TUESDAY — ORDER NUMBER 5041."
SHOWS YOU THE ORDER FIRST, SO YOU CAN CONFIRM IT'S THE RIGHT ONE,
THEN DELETES IT ON YOUR APPROVAL.
```

## Supported systems today

Pier's database helper works with **MySQL** and **MariaDB** databases — which covers WordPress, Joomla, Drupal, Magento, PrestaShop, WooCommerce and virtually every other common website engine.

PostgreSQL and SQLite support will come in later updates.

CHAPTER 10

# Everyday tips that save time.

## Keyboard shortcuts worth learning

| Shortcut | What it does |
|---|---|
| ⌘ + Enter | Send your message without moving to the mouse |
| ⌘ + K | Jump to the chat from anywhere in the app |
| ⌘ + S | Save the open file editor |
| ⌘ + F | Search your whole chat history (great for "didn't I ask about this last month?") |
| ? | Open the full shortcut list |
| Escape | Close any pop-up, cancel a pending question |

## When in doubt, just ask Pier

If you're not sure how to phrase something, the reliably best thing is to describe what you'd like to end up with, not the step-by-step. Pier works out the steps.

## Give connections clear names

Six months from now, you won't remember which one is "web01" and which is "web07". "Client X — production" and "Client X — staging" will be obvious at a glance.

## Use read-only mode on scary sites

For the client site you really don't want to break, lock the connection to read-only except when you're actively making a change. Pier will politely refuse to write until you unlock it.

## Try the full audit every few months

A full audit takes about five minutes to run and surfaces dozens of small improvements. Most of them you can accept in one click each. Your site health drifts over time; the audit nudges it back.

CHAPTER 11

# When something doesn't work.

Almost every problem you hit with Pier falls into one of a few buckets. Here's how to tell them apart — and how to get past them.

### "Connection failed" after I click Test

Nine times out of ten this is a typo. Double-check the host, username, and password against your hosting welcome email. The host usually looks like *ftp.yourdomain.com* or similar — not *www.yourdomain.com*. Your hosting dashboard password is often different from your FTP password.

If you're certain the details are right, try a different connection type from the dropdown. Some hosts quietly turn off old FTP in favour of SFTP only, or the reverse.

### "Too many attempts — please wait"

Some hosting providers block your IP address for a while if Pier (or anything else) tries the wrong password a few times in a row. Wait 15-30 minutes and try again, with correct details this time. If it persists, your host's support team can unblock you.

### I accepted a change but the site doesn't show it

Two likely causes:

- Your website is using a cache. WordPress in particular often has a caching plugin that serves the old version for a while. Clear the cache from your admin dashboard.
- Your web host runs a server-level cache. Wait a few minutes, or contact your host to clear it.

### My license key isn't working

Re-copy the key directly from your purchase email — not from a screenshot. Pier handles line breaks in pasted keys. If you already used both seats, deactivate one from Settings on an older Mac, or email us.

# More things that can go sideways.

### Pier says the database helper won't install

A few hosting providers are strict about what they'll run. Symptoms: the install step fails with a message about "500 server error" or "access denied". Your hosting support can usually fix this in thirty seconds by enabling PHP in the relevant folder, or whitelisting the helper.

### The proposed change looks wrong

Click Reject. Tell Pier what was wrong: *"don't change the word 'store' in the navigation, I only meant the one in the footer"*. Pier re-drafts with your clarification.

### Pier is slow on my very large site

Big sites with tens of thousands of files can be slow over FTP. Try:

- Setting a working folder that limits Pier to the part of the site you're working on.
- Switching the connection from FTP to SFTP, which tends to be faster on busy shared hosts.
- Asking your host whether they'll enable parallel connections — Pier can take advantage if they do.

### Pier can't find something I know exists

Make sure you're on the right connection, and that the working folder (if set) covers the area you're asking about. Pier won't go outside the working folder even if you ask it nicely — by design.

### None of the above helped — what then?

Write to info@abn.company. Tell us what you were trying to do and what happened instead. We usually reply within a working day, and we fix real bugs fast.

CHAPTER 12

# Privacy, security, and your data.

Pier is built around a simple principle: your website's contents and your passwords are yours. They stay on your Mac and on your hosting. We don't want a copy and we don't keep one.

## What stays on your Mac only

- The password to your website.
- Your chat history with Pier.
- The backups Pier makes before every change.
- Your license key, so you don't have to re-enter it.

All of these are stored in Pier's private folder on your Mac, with strong encryption on the sensitive parts.

## What goes out to the internet, and where

- **To your website.** Obviously — Pier has to connect to your site to read and change it. This is the standard secure connection your FTP program uses, encrypted when you pick SFTP or FTPS.
- **To the AI provider.** When you chat with Pier, your message and the relevant files Pier needs to read are sent to the AI (Anthropic's Claude) to get the answer. Your FTP password is never sent, and any sensitive bits of code (keys, passwords inside files) are scrambled out before the AI sees anything.
- **To our license server, weekly.** To check your license is still valid. We see your license ID and that you're still using Pier. We don't see anything about your website or the work you're doing.

## What we don't do

- We don't collect telemetry — no tracking of what you click, what files you open, how long you use Pier for.
- We don't keep copies of your data on any server we control.
- We don't sell anything about you to anyone. Full stop.

# GDPR, AI training, and the small print.

## GDPR compliance

Because Pier keeps your personal and business data on your Mac — not on our servers — there's almost no ongoing data-processing relationship between us and you. We process your email address and payment information at purchase time, and hold your license record on our server so we can verify it's valid. The full privacy policy is at pier.abn.company/legal/privacy.

## Is my code used to train AI?

No. Pier talks to the AI through a paid-API relationship, and the AI provider's terms for API use explicitly exclude your content from training data.

## What happens if we go out of business

Pier continues working on your Mac. The only thing that would stop working is the weekly license check — after which Pier gives you a 7-day grace period and then 60 days of gentle warnings before the AI chat is gated. File browsing, existing backups, and previously written conversations always remain available.

## Your data on your own terms

At any point you can export your chat history as a file, browse your backups in Finder, delete Pier entirely (your website is untouched), or ask us to delete your account from our license server.

CHAPTER 13

# Frequently asked questions.

### Do I need to know anything about coding to use Pier?

No. The whole point of Pier is that you don't. If you can write an email, you can use Pier.

### Does Pier work with Windows or Linux?

Not right now. Pier is Mac-only. A Windows version is technically possible but isn't planned for the foreseeable future.

### Can I use Pier on a site that's not mine?

Yes — freelancers and agencies do this all the time. Each connection is just a set of FTP details. Add as many as you like.

### What if I don't have the FTP details for my site?

Ask your hosting provider's support. Say: "I need my SFTP (or FTP) host, username, and password". They'll email them back, often within an hour.

### Will Pier ever make changes without me approving them?

No, with two tiny exceptions — creating a new empty folder or renaming a file. Both are instantly reversible. Every content change is a proposal you approve.

### What happens if I accidentally accept a bad change?

Click Undo in the 10-second toast. If it's already gone, open the file's History and restore the version from a minute ago. Pier keeps your changes for a rolling 90 days by default.

### Can Pier delete my whole website?

In theory — if you gave it write access and approved a series of deletions one by one. In practice, no. There's no bulk-delete primitive. You'd have to individually approve each deletion.

### Is my site's data used to train AI?

No. We pay for paid-API access, which explicitly excludes your content from training.

# A few more.

### How many sites can I connect at once?

As many as you like. Agencies routinely have 30–50 connections in the sidebar.

### How much does Pier cost after the first year?

Nothing. It's a one-time purchase; there's no subscription, no annual renewal, no "pro plan" you eventually need. All future updates to Pier 1 are free forever.

### Can I try Pier before I buy?

We currently don't have a free trial because we wanted to focus on making the paid experience excellent first. But we do offer a 14-day, no-questions-asked refund. Buy it, try it, and if it isn't for you, we'll give your money back.

### What if I find a bug?

Email info@abn.company with what happened. We treat real bugs as a fire. Most get fixed in the next release, which is usually within a week or two.

### I have an idea for a feature.

We'd love to hear it. Same address. The roadmap is almost entirely driven by what our customers ask for. Concrete use cases help most — describe the job you're trying to get done, and we'll figure out the how.

### Who are you people?

A Brand New Company — a small Dutch software company based in Amsterdam with a remote outpost in Thailand. We've been building tools for website owners for years; Pier is the one we always wished existed.

THANKS FOR READING

Pier — a way to take care of your website without being a developer.
Amsterdam · Sisaket · pier.abn.company · info@abn.company